



Add casual online games to the mix and the list grows even larger. Social networking games such as *Farmville*, *Mafia Wars* and *Poker* encourage user-to-user interaction in terms of gifts, chips and the like. *Typix* is a useful competitive game in work environments – it compares typing speeds among individuals. In the mobile territory, games such as *Word-feud* recently spiked in popularity, with gamers competing on their smartphones.



Moving offline, we've seen people compete with each other over who has the higher *Angry Birds* level score. *Monster Hunter Portable's* popularity in Japan rose to very lofty heights, as players formed parties and traded items using the PSP's ad hoc mode. In the competitive gaming scene, LAN parties and offline tournaments are as popular as always, and the formation of clans at the neighbourhood cyber-cafe is not an uncommon occurrence as gamers converge to get their challenging multiplayer fix. Also popular are gaming lounges, where tournaments are held regularly on top of offering multiplayer action along with food and drinks. These places are ideal for hosting small-scale events, LAN parties or tournaments because of the convenience offered by the all-in-one solution.

Games such as *Starcraft* and *Counter Strike* have massive follow-

GAMING IS A SOCIAL NETWORK



We say that because gaming offers a set of features that most social networks do, and members of the community act in similar ways too!

- Gamers are constantly telling people what's on their mind, or what their gaming status is
- Gamers sometimes take pictures of their purchases or screenshots just so they can upload them and show them off to other gamers
- Most people on social networks are single. Most gamers are single

- Girl gamers are immediately hit with a deluge of friend requests on PSN and Xbox Live
- The above two may or may not be related
- Just like text talk is unfortunately a prominent feature of social networks, l33t speak is a prominent feature of gaming
- People poke each other on Facebook, gamers knife each other
- Clans and parties are the gaming equivalent of groups

ings, with *StarCraft* even becoming a professional sport in Korea. Matches are telecast on TV, and some events attract upto 1.2 lakh people in attendance! Starcrafters are media celebrities out there, with one certain player, Lim Yo-Hwan having a fan club of more than half a million members.

Casual gaming made a huge splash on consoles following the release of the Nintendo Wii, and titles such as *Wii Sports* and *Just Dance* became party staples at gamers' houses. Music games such as *Rock Band* and *Guitar Hero* also support multiplayer, which encourages quite some fun. More recently, Kinect and PlayStation Move added sizzle to casual games on the Xbox 360 and PlayStation 3 with titles such as *Kinect Adventures* and *Sports Champions*.



When it comes to talking about games, gaming forums are the places to go. NeoGAF, for example, has nearly 70,000 registered users who've made a total of nearly 32 million posts. Gamers discuss past, current and upcoming games, cross-platform and post-gaming experiences and gaming hardware. The latest news in the gaming world is also routinely thrown around and dissected, helping you stay up-to-date with information.

Other gaming communities are web sites and tools such as Playfire and Xfire, which provide players with lists of the games they've played or are playing, complete with their ratings and screenshots. They can also create automated forum signatures and the like by tracking your gameplay via achievements. These are a kind of gaming social network, where gamers find like-minded people.

So there you have it! Gamers are fiercely social creatures, despite what people might tell you. Sure, there may be a sizeable number of anti-social gamers, but there are people like that in every community, gamer or not. **d**